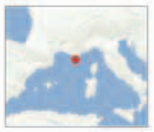
WAR OF THE AUSTRIAN SUCCESSION

TOULON

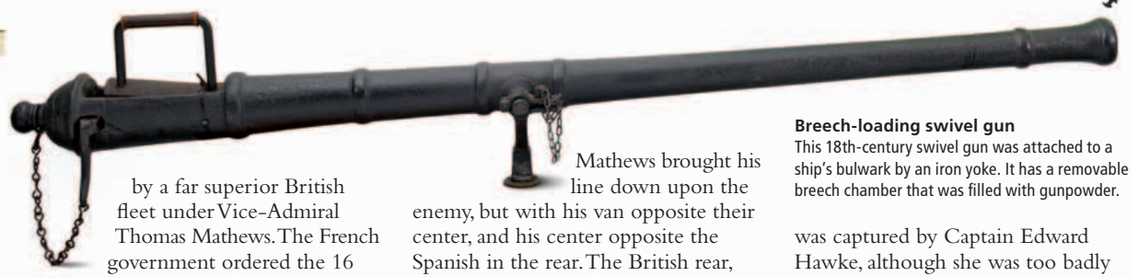


Date February 22–23, 1744
Forces British: 30 ships of the line; French and Spanish: 28 ships of the line
Losses British: none; Spanish: 1 ship of the line burned

Location Off Cape Sicié, southern France

In February 1744 Britain was at war with Spain and Spain was an ally of France, but France was not at war with Britain. This complicated background prepared the way for a confused and unsatisfactory naval encounter. Twelve Spanish ships of the line commanded by Admiral Don José Navarro were trapped in the French port of Toulon by a far superior British fleet under Vice-Admiral Thomas Mathews. The French government ordered the 16 ships of its fleet in Toulon to escort the Spanish out of harbor, but not to seek a fight with the British. The French admiral entrusted with carrying out these difficult instructions was 78-year-old Admiral de Court la Bruyère.

The Allied fleet sailed out of Toulon with French ships making up the van and most of the center and the Spanish in the rear. Holding the weather gage, Mathews brought his line down upon the enemy, but with his van opposite their center, and his center opposite the Spanish in the rear. The British rear, under Vice Admiral Richard Lestock, totally failed to engage the enemy. The choleric Mathews, feeling his ships were holding off, took his flagship *Namur* out of the line to engage the Spanish more closely, but few of his captains followed his example. There was much damaging fire exchanged between *Namur* and Admiral Navarro's *Real Felipe*. One Spanish ship, *Poder*, was captured by Captain Edward Hawke, although she was too badly shattered to be a manageable prize and was later abandoned for the Spanish to scuttle. The battle ended inconclusively with an impression on both sides that it had been conducted incompetently. A score of British officers faced court-martials, including Mathews and Lestock. Remarkably, Lestock was acquitted on a technicality while Mathews was dismissed from service.



Breech-loading swivel gun
This 18th-century swivel gun was attached to a ship's bulwark by an iron yoke. It has a removable breech chamber that was filled with gunpowder.

THE BATTLE OF CAPE FINISTERRE

WAR OF THE AUSTRIAN SUCCESSION



BATTLE OF CAPE FINISTERRE

Date	May 23, 1747
Location	Off Cape Finisterre, Bay of Biscay
Result	British victory

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN	SPAIN

COMMANDERS

George Anson	Jacques-Pierre de la Jonquière

FORCES

Ships: 14 ships of the line, 1 frigate	**Ships:** 5 ships of the line, 2 frigates, 7 others

LOSSES

Men: 520 casualties **Ships:** c.50	**Men:** c.800 casualties **Ships:** 4 ships of the line, 2 frigates, 13 others captured

Recently appointed governor-general of French Canada, Admiral Jacques-Pierre de la Jonquière set sail from France with 24 transport ships and an escort of three ships of the line and two frigates. He was joined by a convoy sent out by the French East India Company with two ships of the line and a number of armed merchantmen. A strong British squadron commanded by Vice Admiral George Anson, sent out to intercept French shipping in the Bay of Biscay, spotted the French ships off northern Spain. De la Jonquière formed all his warships and some of the armed merchantmen into a line of battle, hoping to hold the British off for long enough to allow the slow-moving transports to escape. On his flagship *Prince George* Anson also signaled his ships to form a line, but, at the urging of Rear Admiral Sir Peter Warren, changed the order to a general chase.

> "I CAN WITHOUT VANITY SAY THAT OUR SHIPS WERE BETTER DISCIPLINED AND MADE A MUCH HOTTER FIRE ON THEM."
>
> **ADMIRAL GEORGE ANSON**, IN A LETTER TO THOMAS NEWCASTLE, SECRETARY OF STATE, 1747

The British thus came down upon the outnumbered French led by the 50-gun *Centurion*, which engaged the French rear while other ships came up.

Although hopelessly outgunned, the French fought valiantly in a battle that lasted five hours. La Jonquière's flagship *Sérieux* had every officer wounded. The 40-gun *Gloire* held out for three hours, until her captain was dead and most of her crew injured, before surrendering. But the weight of British broadsides battered the French into submission before nightfall. Through their brave resistance most of the transport ships escaped, only six being taken. The East Indiamen yielded £300,000 in booty for the victors.

A second, broadly similar, battle of Cape Finisterre was fought later in the same year. On October 25 a British squadron of 14 ships of the line under Admiral Edward Hawke intercepted a French convoy bound for the Caribbean with an escort of eight ships of the line under the Marquis Desherbiers de l'Etanduère. Again the British admiral ordered a general chase; once more the French fought against overwhelming odds; and again the convoy was saved at the expense of its escorts. Six French ships of the line were taken.



Overwhelming odds
British and French ships engage off Cape Finisterre. Lord Anson's flagship *Prince George* opens fire in the center.